International Space Station, Russia suggested compensation for loss of the Indian contract and the $400m paid by the United States for seven American flights to Mir may have become part of the equation.

In a revised agreement with India in January 1994, Russia agreed to transfer three, later renegotiated by the Indians to seven, KVD-1s intact, without the associated technology, for a price of $9m. The negotiations were later described as very tough, but the Indians managed to negotiate a lower price and extra engines in exchange for the loss of technology transfer. In addition, two models would be supplied to test how they would best fit the launcher shroud. India was required by the United States to agree to use the equipment purely for peaceful purposes, not to re-export it or modernize it without Russia's consent.'

Brian Harvey was not entirely wrong when he said that 'development of the Indian upper stage with Russian help had been underway for four years when the arrangements were denounced by American President George Bush as a violation of the Missile Technology Control Regime. Harvey got it wrong when he said four years, though.

In the same chapter, 'The rocket engine frontier', Harvey says rather vaguely: 'According to some American sources, the Russians transferred the production technology in any case. The appropriate documents, instruments and equipment were allegedly transferred in four shipments from Moscow to Delhi on covert flights by Ural Airlines. As a cover, they used "legitimate" transshipments of Indian aircraft technology travelling the other way to Moscow for testing in Russian wind-tunnels.'

This, again, was not entirely wrong. India did bring documents, instruments and equipment from Russia, but all of them were legitimate and abiding by the first contract India and Russia had.

But was it a covert operation?

Yes, and also perfectly legit.

Here is why.

Soon after we got information from Glavkosmos that it would not be able to honour the contract, I flew down to meet Dunayev.